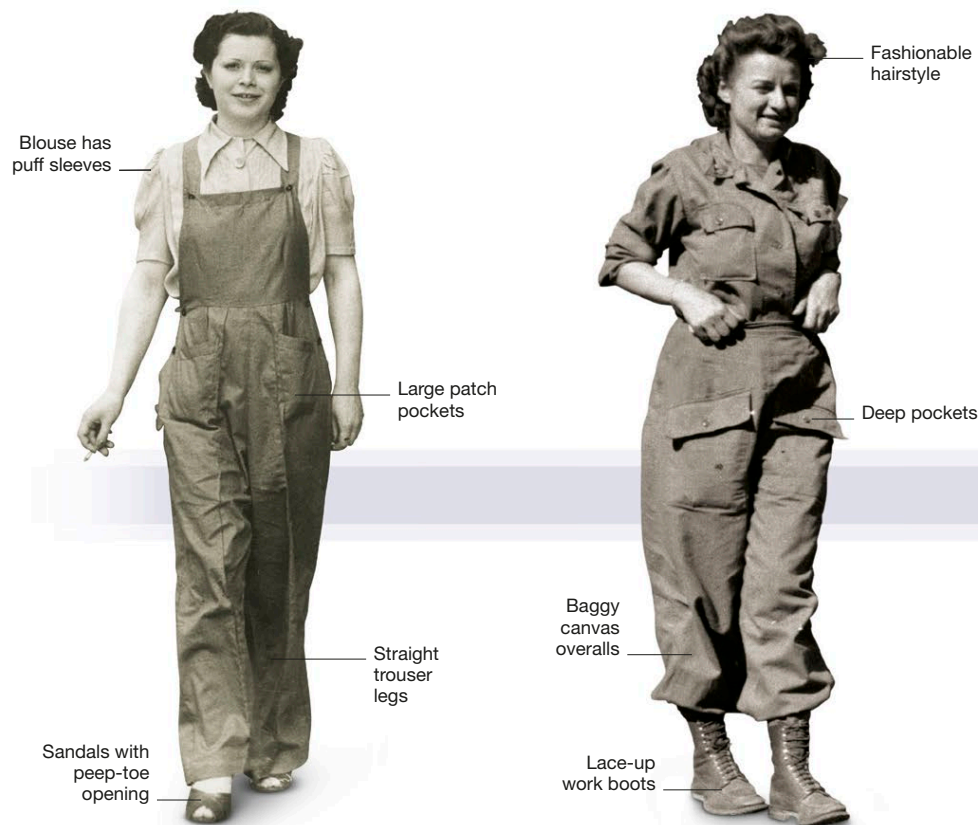


1939–1945

WOMEN IN WARTIME

During World War II nearly half a million women served in the British armed forces; around 400,000 joined the US army, and an even greater number was involved in voluntary services. An attractive uniform could work as a recruiting tool and the blue double-breasted jacket and skirt of the British Women's Royal Naval Service (WRENS) was considered especially becoming. In contrast, *Life* magazine remarked that the "Women's Land Army is unpopular because of the drab costume". Ladies of means had uniforms made to measure at Austin Reed and Moss Bros; others had to alter and adjust the standard issue. Regulations not only governed dress – members of the Women's Auxiliary Air Force had to ensure that their hair was cut or coiffed so that it did not touch their jackets. Some services tried in vain to ban make-up, but this proved difficult to enforce.



Bib and braces This young woman might have chosen her outfit because cotton "bib and brace" overalls did not use up any of her rationing coupons. She has swapped her work shoes for peep-toe sandals.

Overalls Going about her wartime occupation, this woman sports heavy-duty overalls and solid leather boots. Despite the masculine clothing, she maintains her femininity with her carefully styled hairdo.

KNITTING



Knitting pattern

Women were urged to assist in the war effort by knitting gloves, scarves, gum-boot stockings, knee caps, and chest protectors for "our boys in the forces". The scarcity of wool meant that knitters were encouraged to unpick their old garments. In the US the Red Cross issued pamphlets with patterns and instructions, and was responsible for the distribution of the knitted items. America's "first lady", Eleanor Roosevelt, addressed a "Knit for Defense" tea in New York, and was frequently photographed knitting.



Summer uniform This woman working in a US Naval Base in Texas wears a uniform similar to that of a US army private. The outfit is made from cotton khaki. Women's trousers usually fastened at the side.

Land Army The Women's Land Army uniform included corduroy or whipcord breeches and long-sleeved, cotton twill overalls worn with brown brogues and fawn knee-length socks. Recruits also wore a green V-neck jumper, fawn shirt, and tie.